

Colour

Colour is among the most important elements of art. Early natural pigments from plants and minerals were limited, inconsistent and often costly, but after 1704, brighter and cheaper synthetic pigments were developed. In 1810, Johann Wolfgang von Goethe (1749–1832) wrote about colour as an emotional force. Following this, Turner created several compositions using just primary colours: red, yellow and blue, with white and black. Later, Mondrian did the same, but profoundly differently.

Following Chevreul's 1839 book *The Law of Simultaneous Colour Contrast*, Delacroix experimented with simultaneous contrast; the theory that two adjacent complementary colours appear unusually bright. Complementaries are opposites on a colour wheel, that is: red-green, blue-orange, and yellow-violet. In the early 20th century, Matisse and the German Expressionists painted with vivid, unnatural colours, and Klee and Wassily Kandinsky explored unexpected colour relationships. Yves Klein, David Hockney and Joan Miró also exploited vibrant synthetic pigments.



Joseph Anton Koch, *Heroic Landscape with Rainbow*, 1805